

Most and almost

Learner workbook

Distinguish a majority from something nearly true.

Understand the distinction

Most before a plural or uncountable noun means the majority or greatest part: most students, most water. Use most of before a determiner or pronoun: most of the students; most of them.

Almost means nearly: almost ready, almost all, almost everyone. It does not normally directly modify a plural noun to mean the majority: say most people or almost all people, depending on your meaning. Almost all is stronger than most.

Compare the patterns

MAJORITY

Most students came.

More than half came; the precise number is unstated.

NEARLY EVERYONE

Almost all the students came.

Very few were absent.

NEARLY A STATE

The room is almost ready.

Some preparation remains.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Correct this: Almost people arrived on time.

2. Complete: Most ___ them agreed.

3. Which suggests a larger share: most / almost all?

Use it in your own life

Describe a group using most, then describe something nearly finished.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. Most people arrived on time.

If nearly everyone arrived on time, use Almost all the people instead.

2. of

Use of before a pronoun such as them.

3. almost all

It means nearly the entire group.

One possible response

Most of my classmates walk to school. Our project is almost finished.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-37.html